

ANI

INDIA'S FORWARD MARCH

- **Adoption of a military doctrine** centred on deep precision strikes, multi-domain warfare under a 'zero-tolerance' policy against terrorism
- **Increased deployment** of S-400s, push for Project Kusha & Mission Sudarshan Chakra; integration of Akashteer, IACCS and TRIGUN AD networks
- **New investment in swarm drones**, AI-enabled UAVs, Ashni drone platoons, High-Altitude Pseudo Satellites for ISR
- **Development of new long-range** missiles; integration of latest BrahMos, offensive EW systems, network-centric combat
- **Raising of Bhairav battalions** and Rudra brigades for rapid integrated operations
- **Greater triservice coordination** involving greater intelligence-sharing and joint multi-domain warfare capabilities

BrahMos and SCALP missiles that hit deep and hard at eight of its air bases, leading to a ceasefire. Operation Sindoor was a short and sharp affair, and represents a paradigm shift in India-Pakistan conflicts.

It demonstrated India's ability to impose a calibrated escalation and penetrate deep into Pakistan, while revealing cracks within Pakistan's operational readiness, command structure and deterrence credibility. In the following months, the Indian military sped up its modernisation, whereas Pakistan was pushed into urgent command restructuring, defence pacts and emergency procurements from China and Turkey.

INDIA GEARS UP

Op. Sindoor marked a decisive change in India's military doctrine—a transition towards technology-driven and integrated warfare. The conflict also altered India's strategic doctrine. A formal "zero-tolerance" policy now treats any major terrorist attack on Indian soil as an act of war.

Speaking on the anniversary of the conflict on May 7, Deputy Chief of the Army Staff (Strategy) Lt Gen. Rajiv Ghai, who was director general military operations during Op. Sindoor, said no terror sanctuary across the LOC was safe. "We will hit everything...go after everything.... But the conditions, timing and method will be ours," Lt Gen. Ghai said.



"NO TERROR SANCTUARY ACROSS THE LOC IS SAFE. WE WILL HIT AND GO AFTER EVERYTHING.... BUT THE CONDITIONS, THE TIMING AND THE METHOD WILL BE OURS"

— LT GEN. RAJIV GHAI
Deputy Chief of the Army Staff (Strategy)

For India, the past year has seen a massive emphasis on air defence and counter-drone warfare. Though Pakistani drones and missiles were intercepted, this is considered an evolving threat—India has accelerated deployment of S-400 air defence systems, advanced the indigenous Project Kusha (a long-range surface-to-air missile programme) and further intensified the AD integration between the army's Akashteer system, the IAF's Integrated Air Command and Control System (IACCS), and the Navy's TRIGUN. Mission Sudarshan Chakra aims to build a unified national air defence shield. The conflict also demonstrated the efficacy of decades-old artillery pieces like the Bofors L70 anti-aircraft guns and Pechora S-125 surface-to-air missiles, which provided a shield against Pakistani drones.

Drone warfare moved to the centre of military planning after Op. Sindoor highlighted the importance of loitering munitions, kamikaze drones, swarm systems and surveillance platforms, leading to an increased investment in indigenous low-cost Unmanned Aeral Vehicles (UAVs) and AI-enabled autonomous, EW-resistant systems. India has also accelerated the development of precision-guided munitions and deep-strike missiles beyond the 300 km range.

THE MILITARY PIVOTS

With PAF fighter jets posing a threat during Op. Sindoor, the IAF is prioritising beyond-visual-range combat, integrated air battlespace management and network-centric warfare. Combat aircraft modernisation received a boost—there is focus on more Rafale acquisitions and on the indigenous multi-role stealth Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA) programme.

The conflict reinforced the growing importance of cyber warfare and digital infrastructure security. India is now integrating cyber defence and counter-disinformation operations more closely into military planning.

Organisationally, the army moved the fastest. It raised Bhairav Battalions—light commando units trained for rapid cross-border and mountain operations with integrated drone expertise. Rudra Brigades emerged as combined formations integrating infantry, armour, artillery, drones and AD. Ashni Drone Platoons were introduced across infantry battalions, embedding drones into frontline combat formations.

Finally, triservice integration has become central to India's military doctrine. Joint operational planning, integrated execution, logistics modernisation and surveillance expansion have accelerated.